

GREAT SCIENTISTS

Aristotle

Perhaps the greatest thinker of his time, Greek philosopher and scientist Aristotle (384–322 BCE) had huge influence in the ancient world. Later, in the Middle Ages, his work was very important to Islamic scholars, through whom it then reached Europe. Aristotle's astonishing range of studies included logic, politics, mathematics, biology, and physics.

Early philosophers

Long before Aristotle's time, Greek philosophers such as Anaximenes of Miletus (who died in 528 BCE) had looked for scientific explanations for what went on in the natural world. For instance, they came up with various theories on what substance made up the Universe (Anaximenes thought it was air).

At the Academy

In his teens, Aristotle went to study at the Academy in the city of Athens, a school founded by the Greek philosopher Plato (427–347 BCE). Plato himself was a former student of Socrates (c 470–399 BCE), another great Greek thinker. Plato had many ideas, still discussed today, about what is real and what exists just in our minds. Aristotle, however, had a more practical outlook and learned to reason things out. He was greatly interested in understanding nature and classifying the differences between animals.

Politics and society

Aristotle was also interested in people and politics. He called people "political animals," best suited to living in a society, ideally a city-state like Athens, rather than alone. He later founded his own school, the Lyceum in Athens, and became famous as a teacher.

Aristotle's legacy

Aristotle's works were rediscovered in western Europe in the 12th and 13th centuries. His ideas influenced theologians (people who study God and faith) such as Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274) and his works on politics were widely read. This manuscript is a French translation of Aristotle's work *Politics* by the scholar Nicholas of Oresme.

Page from Aristotle's *Politics* illustrating workers in the fields.



Alexander's tutor

In 343 BCE, King Philip II of Macedon, Greece, invited Aristotle to tutor his son, later Alexander the Great. Aristotle taught him for many years. Alexander carried with him on his campaigns a copy of the Greek epic poem *The Iliad* given to him by Aristotle.

“Man is much more a political animal than any kind of bee or herd animal.”

Aristotle, *Politics*

A stationary Earth formed the center of Aristotle's Universe.



Each planet was thought to sit on a sphere.

Model of Aristotle's Earth-centric Universe

Astronomical theory

Aristotle believed that Earth was situated at the center of the Universe. He suggested that the other heavenly bodies, such as the Sun and the planets, orbited Earth on concentric spheres.

